figure in monographs on Ashoka, but usually in separate sections or chapters dedicated to archaeological sites and monuments. Here, I have woven the places and landscapes into a narrative of the contexts in which Ashoka's life was lived. Juxtaposing his royal messages with the contextual flesh of surrounding landscapes has enabled me to highlight the ways in which the messages themselves were shaped, influenced, enhanced, and modified.

All of this—the epigraphs, the archaeology, the life—are part of the enormous outpouring of writings on an unforgettable monarch. Yet I think my weave is different. The carpet I will lay out blends the landmarks of life and landscapes to give another picture of the life and times of Ashoka in ancient India.